



Polygon Pedagogues Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy

For children and young people under 18

Policy owner	Mohsin Abbas, Primary DSL
Approved by	Hammad Ahmad, Company Director and Deputy DSL
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Policy category	Safeguarding and Child Protection
Applies to	All staff, tutors, directors, volunteers and contractors

Designated Safeguarding Contacts

The following safeguarding contacts must be kept current and are communicated to all staff and tutors before they begin work. If a child is in immediate danger or needs urgent medical attention, call 999 first.

Role	Contact details
Primary Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) (Level 3 safeguarding-trained)	Mohsin Abbas dsl@polygonpedagogues.co.uk 07305 237933
Deputy DSL and Company Director (on-call)	Hammad Ahmad director@polygonpedagogues.co.uk 07555 854902
Out-of-hours safeguarding escalation	Mohsin Abbas, Primary DSL: 07305 237933 If unavailable, Hammad Ahmad, Deputy DSL: 07555 854902
Emergency action	Call 999 if a child is in immediate danger. If both DSLs are unavailable and delay could place a child at risk, contact children's social care or the police directly; notify the DSL as soon as possible.

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1. Purpose of this Policy

The purpose of this safeguarding and child protection policy is to explain how Polygon Pedagogues protects children and young people who use its tuition services. Safeguarding is not an optional addition to teaching; it is central to safe, effective and professional education practice. This policy sets out the standards expected from every adult who works for, represents, manages or delivers services on behalf of Polygon Pedagogues.

Polygon Pedagogues provides private and commissioned tuition in English, mathematics and science for school-age learners, including support through A-level where agreed. Many learners may have special educational needs and disabilities, social, emotional or mental health needs, communication difficulties, anxiety, school avoidance, low confidence, trauma-related needs, disrupted education or other additional vulnerabilities. The policy therefore reflects the additional safeguarding considerations that may arise in one-to-one outreach, home tuition, online tuition and small-group provision.

This policy explains how Polygon Pedagogues protects children from abuse, neglect, exploitation and harm; creates safe learning environments in homes, schools, community venues and online; ensures tutors understand their safeguarding responsibilities; responds quickly to concerns and disclosures; recruits safely; and works appropriately with parents, carers, schools, local authorities, children's social care, police and other safeguarding partners.

The welfare of the child is always the paramount consideration. Where there is any conflict between business convenience, parental preference, tutor availability, contractual arrangements or child safety, the protection and welfare of the child comes first.

2. Service Context and Scope

This policy applies to all activities carried out by Polygon Pedagogues, including one-to-one tuition, small-group tuition, home tuition, online tuition, tuition in schools, libraries, community venues or hired spaces, assessment sessions, trial sessions, initial consultations, and all communication with children, parents, carers, schools and other professionals.

The policy applies to tuition commissioned privately by parents or carers and to tuition commissioned by schools, local authorities or other organisations. It applies to every person working for or on behalf of Polygon Pedagogues, including employees, self-employed tutors, subcontractors, agency staff, consultants, volunteers and directors. No person is exempt from the policy because of their job title, seniority, employment status or length of service.

Where a school, local authority or other commissioning organisation has its own safeguarding policy, Polygon Pedagogues works within those arrangements as well as this policy. If there is any uncertainty about which process applies, staff seek advice from the DSL. Uncertainty about process never delays immediate action where a child may be at risk of harm.

Polygon Pedagogues operates as a private tuition, outreach and alternative education provider and is not a registered independent school at the date of this policy. The Directors keep the service model under review and will obtain registration before delivering full-time education in circumstances that require it. Polygon Pedagogues follows the safeguarding expectations in

education guidance as a professional benchmark and, where provision is commissioned, works within the commissioning school's or local authority's arrangements.

3. Safeguarding Principles

Safeguarding and promoting the welfare of children is everyone's responsibility. All adults working with children maintain an attitude that harm could happen in any family, community, online space or educational arrangement. Staff do not wait for proof before sharing a concern; they report what they have seen, heard or been told so that the DSL can consider the wider safeguarding picture.

Every child has the right to be safe, respected, listened to and protected from harm. Children are treated as individuals, and their age, development, SEND, disability, communication style, language, culture, identity and personal circumstances are considered when decisions are made about their welfare.

Children with SEND and disabilities may face additional safeguarding risks. Changes in behaviour, withdrawal, distress, aggression, poor concentration, refusal to engage or unexplained absence are not automatically assumed to be part of a child's identified need. Staff remain professionally curious and consider whether the behaviour may indicate abuse, neglect, exploitation, anxiety, trauma or another welfare concern.

Information is recorded accurately and shared appropriately where it is necessary to protect a child. Staff do not promise secrecy to a child and do not keep safeguarding concerns to themselves. Parents and carers are normally involved in safeguarding decisions unless doing so could increase risk to the child, another child, the reporting adult or any other person.

4. Legal and Guidance Framework

This policy is written with reference to safeguarding law, statutory guidance and good practice in England. It is read alongside local safeguarding partnership procedures in the area where the child lives or receives tuition. Because safeguarding guidance is regularly updated, Polygon Pedagogues reviews this policy at least annually and sooner if legal or statutory guidance changes require it.

The key framework includes Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026; Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026 (used by Polygon Pedagogues as an education-sector benchmark); the Children Act 1989 and Children Act 2004; the Safeguarding Vulnerable Groups Act 2006; the Protection of Freedoms Act 2012; the Equality Act 2010; the Counter-Terrorism and Security Act 2015; the Female Genital Mutilation Act 2003; the Domestic Abuse Act 2021; the Modern Slavery Act 2015; the Data Protection Act 2018 and UK GDPR; the Human Rights Act 1998; the Sexual Offences Act 2003; and current Disclosure and Barring Service guidance.

Keeping Children Safe in Education is statutory guidance for schools and colleges. Polygon Pedagogues does not present itself as a school; it follows the relevant safeguarding principles as recognised good practice because its staff work directly with children and young people, often in one-to-one or small-group settings.

5. Definitions

A child is anyone who has not yet reached their 18th birthday. A young person remains legally a child even if they are 16 or 17, living independently, in further education, working, in hospital, in care or involved with the criminal justice system.

Safeguarding and promoting the welfare of children means providing help and support as soon as problems emerge; protecting children from maltreatment, including online; preventing impairment of mental and physical health or development; ensuring they grow up with safe and effective care; promoting upbringing within the child's family network where this is safe and appropriate; and enabling children to achieve the best possible outcomes.

Child protection is a specific part of safeguarding. It refers to action taken to protect a child who is suffering, or is likely to suffer, significant harm. Child protection concerns require prompt reporting and may require referral to children's social care, the police or other safeguarding agencies.

Abuse is a form of maltreatment. A person may abuse a child by inflicting harm or by failing to act to prevent harm. Neglect is the persistent failure to meet a child's basic physical or psychological needs and may seriously impair the child's health or development. Exploitation involves a child being manipulated, coerced, deceived, pressured or forced into an activity that benefits another person or group and harms the child.

In this policy, the term staff includes employees, directors, tutors, self-employed contractors, subcontractors, consultants, agency staff and volunteers. The term DSL means Designated Safeguarding Lead. The term LADO means Local Authority Designated Officer, who is responsible for managing and overseeing allegations against adults who work with children.

6. Roles and Responsibilities

All staff and tutors

Every member of staff and every tutor has a personal responsibility to safeguard children. This responsibility is not delegated to another adult and is not avoided because a concern appears uncertain, minor or outside the tutor's teaching role. When a member of staff is worried about a child, they report the concern to the DSL as soon as possible and always within the reporting timescale set by this policy.

All staff and tutors read and follow this policy, complete required safeguarding training before working with learners, understand how to recognise signs of abuse and neglect, maintain appropriate professional boundaries, avoid investigating concerns themselves, and cooperate fully with safeguarding enquiries. Staff never promise confidentiality to a child and explain, in an age-appropriate way, that information may need to be shared with people who can help keep the child safe.

Tutors are often in a strong position to notice early signs of worry because they work closely with learners over time. A learner may disclose information during a lesson, show changes in behaviour, avoid particular topics, appear unusually tired or anxious, miss sessions, or reveal concerns through work, drawings, written responses or online interactions. Tutors treat these signs seriously and share them with the DSL.

Designated Safeguarding Lead

The DSL has lead responsibility for safeguarding and child protection across Polygon Pedagogues. The DSL has the authority, time, training and access to senior leadership needed to act effectively. The DSL receives concerns, assesses risk, makes or supports referrals, consults children's social care, contacts the LADO where required, maintains safeguarding records, and ensures that safeguarding procedures are followed consistently.

The DSL maintains an overview of safeguarding patterns across the service. This includes monitoring repeated concerns about individual learners, repeated concerns about particular settings, patterns of missed sessions, boundary issues, allegations, low-level concerns, online safety incidents and any weakness in staff practice. The DSL also ensures that the safer recruitment record, safeguarding training records and policy review cycle are maintained.

Deputy DSL

The Deputy DSL supports the DSL and acts with full safeguarding authority when the DSL is unavailable. The Deputy DSL receives appropriate training and is able to make timely safeguarding decisions. Staff understand that the Deputy DSL is not a less serious route; where the DSL is unavailable, concerns are shared with the Deputy DSL without delay.

Directors and senior leaders

Directors and senior leaders ensure that safeguarding is properly resourced, visible and prioritised. They make sure that the DSL can act independently where child safety is concerned, that safer recruitment is followed, that safeguarding training is completed, that concerns are reviewed, and that the organisation's commercial interests never override child protection duties.

7. Children with SEND, Disabilities and Additional Vulnerabilities

Polygon Pedagogues recognises that children with special educational needs and disabilities may be more vulnerable to abuse, neglect and exploitation. Some children may depend heavily on adults for support, have difficulty communicating concerns, struggle to understand unsafe behaviour, be more isolated from peers, receive support from multiple adults, or be targeted because of their vulnerability.

Some safeguarding signs may be wrongly attributed to a child's SEND, disability or behaviour profile. For example, withdrawal, refusal to engage, aggression, shutdown, anxiety, poor attendance, emotional dysregulation or sudden loss of progress may be interpreted as learning difficulty or behaviour alone. Staff avoid assumptions and consider whether the change could be linked to harm, neglect, exploitation, bullying, trauma, mental health difficulties or problems in the home or online environment.

Before tuition begins, Polygon Pedagogues seeks relevant information about the learner's needs from parents, carers and, where applicable, the commissioning organisation. Where an Education, Health and Care Plan, learning support plan, risk assessment or other professional information is available and relevant, it is considered so that tuition is delivered safely and inclusively.

Reasonable adjustments are made so that children can communicate and participate safely. This may include using clear language, visual supports, planned breaks, adapted questioning, alternative ways to express worries, predictable routines and additional liaison with parents, carers or professionals. The child's voice is heard wherever possible, and staff avoid speaking only through adults when the child can communicate their views directly or with support.

8. Recognising Abuse, Neglect and Exploitation

All staff and tutors are alert to signs that a child may be suffering or at risk of harm. Abuse, neglect and exploitation are often complex and overlapping. A single sign may not prove that a child is being harmed, but it may still be important when considered alongside other information. Staff record and report concerns rather than trying to decide alone whether a legal threshold has been met.

Physical abuse

Physical abuse may involve hitting, shaking, throwing, poisoning, burning, scalding, drowning, suffocating, inappropriate restraint or otherwise causing physical harm to a child. It may also include a parent or carer fabricating symptoms of illness or deliberately causing illness in a child. Possible indicators include unexplained injuries, injuries with inconsistent explanations, repeated bruising, flinching, fear of going home, wearing clothes that seem intended to hide injuries, or worrying explanations from adults.

Emotional abuse

Emotional abuse is persistent emotional maltreatment that harms a child's emotional development. It may include humiliating, threatening, ignoring, rejecting, isolating, blaming, silencing, mocking or making a child feel worthless or unloved. Tutors may notice low self-esteem, anxiety, fear of making mistakes, extreme compliance, aggression, withdrawal, tearfulness, delayed development or sudden changes in engagement.

Sexual abuse

Sexual abuse involves forcing or enticing a child to take part in sexual activities, whether or not the child understands what is happening. It may involve physical contact or non-contact abuse, including grooming, sexual conversations, exposure to sexual images, the production or sharing of sexual images, or online sexual exploitation. Possible indicators include sexualised language or behaviour inappropriate for age, secrecy, fear of a particular person or place, unexplained gifts, self-harm, nightmares, distress or disclosure.

Neglect

Neglect is the persistent failure to meet a child's basic physical or psychological needs. It may involve failure to provide food, clothing, shelter, supervision, medical care, emotional warmth, safety or access to education. Tutors may notice hunger, tiredness, poor hygiene, untreated medical needs, unsuitable clothing, lack of supervision, repeated missed sessions, or a child taking on responsibilities that are inappropriate for their age.

Domestic abuse

Children can be victims of domestic abuse when they see, hear or experience its effects. Domestic abuse may include physical, emotional, sexual, psychological, controlling, coercive or economic abuse. During home or online tuition, tutors may hear shouting, threats or violence, notice a child becoming fearful when a particular adult enters the room, or observe signs of distress linked to the home environment. Any concern is reported to the DSL.

Child-on-child abuse

Children can abuse other children in person or online. This may include bullying, cyberbullying, prejudice-based bullying, physical abuse, sexual harassment, sexual violence, sharing nude or semi-nude images, coercive behaviour, threats, humiliation, hazing or abuse in teenage relationships. Polygon Pedagogues has a zero-tolerance approach to child-on-child abuse. Staff never dismiss harmful behaviour as banter, joking, immaturity or a normal part of growing up.

Child sexual exploitation and child criminal exploitation

Child sexual exploitation and child criminal exploitation occur where a child is manipulated, coerced, deceived, pressured or forced into sexual or criminal activity. Exploitation may involve gifts, money, status, affection, threats, violence, drugs, debt, transport, accommodation or online grooming. Indicators may include unexplained money or possessions, older friends or partners, secretive phone use, going missing, poor attendance, changes in behaviour, fear, aggression, carrying weapons or involvement with gangs or county lines.

County lines and serious violence

County lines involves criminal networks exploiting children to move drugs or money. Children may appear to be making choices, but they may be controlled by fear, violence, debt or threats against themselves or their family. Concerns about weapons, threats, criminal exploitation, serious violence or gang involvement are reported immediately to the DSL, and 999 is called if there is immediate danger.

Online safety and technology-related harm

Technology is a significant part of many safeguarding risks. Children may experience online grooming, bullying, harassment, sexual exploitation, coercion, radicalisation, scams, harmful content, pressure to share images, or abuse through messaging platforms and social media. Tutors report concerns about inappropriate online contact, sexual messages, cyberbullying, harmful communities, radicalising content, self-harm content, unsafe device use or concerning behaviour observed during online tuition.

Radicalisation and Prevent

Polygon Pedagogues is not automatically a specified authority for the statutory Prevent duty. It nevertheless requires staff to be alert to indicators that a child may be susceptible to radicalisation, complete appropriate Prevent awareness training and follow the relevant procedures of commissioning schools and local authorities. Tutors are not expected to be experts: they report concerns to the DSL, who considers local Prevent advice or referral through safeguarding routes.

Female genital mutilation

Female genital mutilation (FGM) is child abuse and illegal. Any concern that a girl may be at risk of FGM, or may have experienced it, is reported to the DSL immediately. A teacher or other regulated professional who identifies a known case of FGM in a girl under 18 during their professional work must personally make the mandatory report to the police and then inform the DSL.

Forced marriage and so-called honour-based abuse

Forced marriage and so-called honour-based abuse are safeguarding concerns and may involve threats, control, violence, pressure, isolation or removal from education. Staff report any concern to the DSL. If a child appears to be at immediate risk of being taken abroad, harmed or forced into marriage, staff call 999 and seek urgent safeguarding support.

Mental health, self-harm and suicidal thoughts

Mental health concerns may be linked to abuse, neglect, exploitation, trauma, bullying or other harm. Tutors do not attempt to diagnose a mental health condition, but they report concerns where a child talks about wanting to die, has a plan to harm themselves, has recently self-harmed, appears at immediate risk, or discloses serious distress without a safe adult available. In an emergency, staff call 999 and inform the DSL.

Children missing education or repeated absence

Repeated missed tuition, sudden withdrawal, unexplained cancellations, a family becoming unreachable, or a child disappearing from online sessions may indicate a welfare concern. Attendance patterns are monitored because children who are missing education or who are absent repeatedly may be at increased risk of harm. Where tuition is commissioned by a school or local authority, attendance concerns are reported in line with the agreed procedure.

9. Responding to Safeguarding Concerns

If a member of staff believes that a child is in immediate danger or requires urgent medical attention, they call 999 immediately. They then take reasonable steps to keep the child safe without placing themselves or others at unnecessary risk, and they inform the DSL as soon as it is safe to do so.

Where the concern is not an immediate emergency, the tutor or staff member still acts promptly. They listen, observe, record the facts and report the concern to the DSL as soon as possible and always within 24 hours. Urgent concerns are reported immediately by phone, not left only in an email or written note.

Staff do not investigate concerns themselves. Their role is to pass information to the DSL so that appropriate safeguarding action can be considered. Investigation by an untrained staff member may contaminate evidence, frighten the child, alert a person who may pose a risk, or delay proper safeguarding action.

If the DSL and Deputy DSL are unavailable and delay could place a child at risk, staff contact local authority children's social care, the police or emergency services directly. The DSL is then informed as soon as possible. The absence of the DSL is never a reason for doing nothing.

10. Responding to a Disclosure from a Child

If a child tells a tutor or staff member that they are being abused, neglected, exploited or harmed, the adult stays calm and listens carefully. The child is allowed to speak freely without interruption, pressure or disbelief. The adult reassures the child that they have done the right thing by telling someone and that the information is taken seriously.

The adult does not promise to keep the information secret. Instead, they explain in simple and age-appropriate language that they may need to share the information with people who can help keep the child safe. A suitable response is: 'Thank you for telling me. I am glad you told me. I cannot keep this secret because I need to help keep you safe. I only share it with people who need to know and can help.'

Staff avoid leading questions. They may use open prompts such as 'Tell me what happened' or 'Is there anything else you want to tell me?' but they do not ask questions that suggest an answer or attempt to establish proof. The child is not asked to repeat the disclosure unnecessarily to multiple adults.

After the disclosure, the adult makes an accurate written record as soon as possible, using the child's own words where possible, and reports the matter to the DSL immediately. If the disclosure suggests immediate danger, the adult calls 999.

11. Recording Safeguarding Concerns

Safeguarding records are clear, accurate, factual and completed as soon as possible after the concern arises. A good record allows the DSL and external agencies to understand what happened, when it happened, who was present, what was said, and what action was taken. Poor recording can make it harder to protect a child and may affect later safeguarding decisions.

Each record includes the child's name, date of birth or year group if known, the date and time of the concern, the location or session type, the name and role of the person recording, what was seen, heard or disclosed, the child's exact words where possible, who else was present, what immediate action was taken, who was informed, and the DSL's decision and follow-up action.

Records separate fact from opinion. Staff do not use emotional language, assumptions, judgemental descriptions or unsupported conclusions. If professional judgement is included, it is clearly identified as judgement and supported by observable evidence.

Safeguarding records are stored securely and separately from general tuition records. Access is restricted to the DSL, Deputy DSL and authorised senior leaders. Records are not stored on personal devices, personal email accounts or unapproved cloud systems.

12. Information Sharing, Confidentiality and Data Protection

Safeguarding information is confidential, but confidentiality is never used as a reason not to protect a child. Staff share safeguarding information only with those who need to know, while understanding that appropriate information sharing can be essential to keeping children safe.

A child is never promised that a safeguarding concern is kept secret. Staff explain that information may need to be shared with the DSL, children's social care, police, a school, a local authority, parents or carers, or another relevant professional if that is necessary to protect the child.

Parents and carers are usually informed about concerns, but there are circumstances where this may not be safe. The DSL may decide not to inform parents or carers before taking advice if doing so could place the child at greater risk, place another person at risk, interfere with a police or social care investigation, or increase risk in situations such as sexual abuse, exploitation, fabricated or induced illness, forced marriage, FGM or serious domestic abuse.

Data protection law does not prevent necessary, proportionate and justified information sharing for safeguarding purposes. Where staff are unsure whether to share information, they speak to the DSL. Fear of getting data protection wrong must not stand in the way of action needed to safeguard a child.

13. Safer Recruitment

Polygon Pedagogues is committed to preventing unsuitable people from working with children. Recruitment is planned and documented so that safeguarding is considered at every stage, from advert and application through to interview, checks, induction and ongoing supervision. No adult begins work with learners until required safer recruitment checks have been completed and approved.

Recruitment information makes clear that Polygon Pedagogues is committed to safeguarding and promoting the welfare of children. Application and selection processes explore the candidate's experience, employment history, gaps in employment or education, qualifications where relevant, professional conduct, motivation for working with children, understanding of boundaries and ability to respond appropriately to safeguarding concerns.

Pre-appointment checks include identity, right to work, relevant qualifications, references, employment history and DBS checks where they are lawful and appropriate. Where a role is in regulated activity with children, Polygon Pedagogues obtains an enhanced DBS check with Children's Barred List information before the individual begins that role. Overseas checks or certificates of good conduct are considered where a candidate has lived or worked outside the UK.

Safer recruitment is not limited to a DBS certificate. Polygon Pedagogues considers the full suitability picture, including references, interview answers, conduct during recruitment, any disclosed information, gaps or inconsistencies, and ongoing behaviour after appointment. A single central record or equivalent safeguarding compliance record is maintained.

14. DBS Checks, Barred List Checks and Regulated Activity

Polygon Pedagogues assesses each role against current DBS eligibility and regulated-activity guidance. From 1 September 2026, teaching, training, instructing, caring for or supervising children more than three days in a 30-day period, or overnight, will generally be regulated activity even if another adult supervises the work. Where a role is eligible for an enhanced check but is not regulated activity, a Barred List check is not requested. A person barred from working with children must not be employed, engaged or deployed in regulated activity with children.

A DBS certificate is handled securely and confidentially. DBS information is viewed only by authorised staff and used only to assess suitability for the role. Decisions about disclosed information are fair, risk-based, documented and relevant to the nature of the work with children.

Where a tutor is subscribed to the DBS Update Service, Polygon Pedagogues may complete an Update Service check with the tutor's consent, while still verifying identity and completing other suitability checks. The Update Service is not treated as a replacement for safe recruitment judgement.

If information is disclosed on a DBS certificate or through another recruitment route, Polygon Pedagogues considers the nature of the information, the role, the relevance to working with children, the time elapsed, the candidate's explanation and any safer recruitment advice required. The decision and rationale are recorded.

15. Duty to Refer to the Disclosure and Barring Service

Polygon Pedagogues must make a DBS referral where it is a regulated activity provider or personnel supplier, the statutory conditions are met, and an individual has been removed from regulated activity (or would have been removed had they not left) because there is evidence of relevant conduct, harm or risk of harm, or the harm test is met.

A DBS referral duty is separate from, and may apply alongside, any referral to children's social care, the police, the LADO or a professional body. The DSL and senior leadership record the rationale and make the referral promptly. If legal criteria are not met but serious safeguarding concerns remain, Polygon Pedagogues considers whether a discretionary referral to DBS is appropriate.

Where there is uncertainty, the DSL seeks advice from current DBS guidance, the LADO, an appropriate safeguarding adviser or legal advice. This does not delay action needed to protect a child.

16. Safe Working Practice for Home Tuition

Home tuition can be highly effective for learners, but it creates specific safeguarding considerations because teaching takes place in a private setting. Polygon Pedagogues therefore requires clear rules to protect the learner, the family and the tutor. These rules apply to every in-person session delivered in a family home or similar private setting.

Responsible adult requirement

A responsible adult is present in the home or approved setting throughout every in-person tuition session. A responsible adult may be a parent, carer or another adult authorised by the parent or carer and known to the family. The tutor is not providing childcare and is never left in sole charge of a child.

If a tutor arrives and no responsible adult is present, the tutor does not enter the home or begin the session. They contact Polygon Pedagogues immediately and wait for guidance. If a responsible adult leaves during a session, the tutor explains that they cannot remain alone with the learner, ends the session safely and informs Polygon Pedagogues immediately.

Suitable tuition environment

Tuition takes place in a safe, appropriate and visible area such as a living room, dining room, kitchen or study area. Sessions do not normally take place in a child's bedroom. If there is a genuine reason why no other room is possible, such as disability, medical need or mobility restriction, the arrangement is risk assessed and approved by the DSL or senior manager before the session proceeds.

Where possible, doors remain open, the tutor and learner are visible or within reasonable hearing distance of the responsible adult, seating is professional, the room is well lit, and the tutor has a clear exit route. Tutors report any environmental concern, including hazards, aggression, intoxicated adults, unsafe animals, inappropriate material, or anything that makes the session feel unsafe.

Personal care, transport and physical contact

Tutors do not provide personal care, toileting, changing, feeding, medication or medical support unless this has been specifically agreed, risk assessed, trained and written into the child's support plan. In normal tuition arrangements, personal care remains the responsibility of the parent, carer or responsible adult.

Tutors do not transport learners in personal vehicles or accompany them to another location unless this has been formally authorised, risk assessed and agreed in writing by Polygon Pedagogues and the parent or carer. Tutors are not authorised to use restraint. In an immediate emergency, a tutor may take proportionate, reasonable action only to prevent serious and imminent harm, use the minimum intervention needed, call 999 where appropriate and report it to the DSL immediately.

17. Safe Working Practice for Online Tuition

Online tuition is delivered with the same safeguarding seriousness as in-person tuition. Tutors use only platforms or systems approved by Polygon Pedagogues and do not use personal social media, private messaging accounts or informal communication routes to teach or contact learners.

The parent or carer knows when the session is taking place and the learner is in a suitable environment. Tutors deliver sessions from an appropriate professional space, use suitable backgrounds, dress appropriately, keep the session focused on learning and avoid private informal conversations. Sessions are not recorded unless written consent has been obtained from Polygon Pedagogues, the parent or carer and, where appropriate, the learner.

Tutors report anything concerning seen or heard during an online session. This may include background shouting, visible injuries, the presence of an inappropriate adult, neglect indicators, unsafe online behaviour, sexualised language, signs of distress, or anything that suggests the learner is not safe. If the child appears to be in immediate danger, the tutor calls 999 and informs the DSL.

Tutors do not follow learners on social media, accept friend or follow requests from learners, use personal accounts for tuition, take screenshots on personal devices, share personal contact details, or continue a session if the child appears unsafe or the online environment becomes inappropriate.

18. Professional Boundaries and Code of Conduct

All staff and tutors maintain professional boundaries at all times. A safe adult is warm, respectful and encouraging, but does not create secrecy, dependency, favouritism or personal relationships with learners. Boundaries protect children, families and staff from harm, confusion and allegations.

Staff use appropriate language, dress professionally, keep conversations focused on learning and wellbeing, avoid unnecessary personal disclosures, and communicate only through routes approved by Polygon Pedagogues. Staff do not meet learners privately outside agreed tuition, give personal gifts, accept significant gifts, discuss inappropriate personal matters, transport learners, take personal photographs, or communicate secretly with a learner.

Any sexual, romantic, exploitative or emotionally dependent relationship with a learner is strictly prohibited. Staff also understand that conduct outside work may affect their suitability to work with children, particularly where it raises concerns about violence, substance misuse, sexual conduct, discrimination, extremism, dishonesty, online behaviour or risk to children.

If a tutor is unsure whether a behaviour, message, request or situation crosses a professional boundary, they seek advice from the DSL or senior manager before acting. If a boundary has already been crossed, the tutor reports it immediately so that the matter can be managed transparently and safely.

19. Communication with Parents, Carers and Learners

Communication is transparent, professional and proportionate. Tutors normally communicate through parents, carers or systems approved by Polygon Pedagogues. Direct communication with learners happens only where it is necessary, age-appropriate, approved by Polygon Pedagogues and known to the parent or carer.

Messages are limited to tuition matters such as lesson times, homework, learning resources, progress and practical arrangements. Messages are not secretive, personal, excessive, emotionally dependent, flirtatious, discriminatory or sent at inappropriate times. Staff do not move communication to personal platforms such as WhatsApp, Snapchat, Instagram, TikTok or private email unless Polygon Pedagogues has formally approved a specific communication method for a clear reason.

If a child contacts a tutor with a safeguarding concern, the tutor responds supportively but does not enter into a long private conversation. The tutor acknowledges the message, explains that they need to share it with the DSL to help keep the child safe, and reports the concern immediately.

20. Photography, Video, Recordings and Learner Work

Tutors do not take photographs, videos, screenshots or recordings of learners on personal devices. Images and recordings can create serious safeguarding, privacy and data protection risks if taken unnecessarily, stored insecurely or shared without proper consent.

Photographs, videos or recordings are taken only where there is a clear educational, safeguarding or quality assurance purpose, written consent has been obtained, the method has been approved

by Polygon Pedagogues, and the content is stored securely on an approved system. Consent is informed and is not assumed because a parent or learner has previously agreed to another form of communication.

Learner work is not posted online, used for advertising, shared in case studies or included in promotional material without written consent and approval from Polygon Pedagogues. Even where consent is given, identifying details are minimised and the dignity, privacy and safety of the learner are protected.

21. Risk Assessments

Polygon Pedagogues completes appropriate risk assessments before tuition begins and reviews them when circumstances change. Risk assessment is not intended to create unnecessary paperwork; it is a practical safeguarding process that helps identify what could go wrong, how likely it is, how serious it would be and what controls are needed to make tuition safe.

Risk assessments may consider the learner's age, SEND, disability, communication needs, medical or mobility needs, behaviour, mental health, known trauma, home environment, presence of a responsible adult, online safety arrangements, venue suitability, tutor lone working, siblings or other children present, animals in the home, travel arrangements and emergency contacts.

Tutors complete a brief visual and practical safety check at the start of each in-person session. If the environment is unsafe, the tutor does not continue and contacts Polygon Pedagogues. Examples of unsafe circumstances include no responsible adult being present, aggressive behaviour, dangerous hazards, intoxicated adults, unsafe animals, inappropriate rooms, or any situation where the tutor believes the learner or tutor may be at risk.

Risk assessments operate as living documents. If new information emerges, such as a safeguarding disclosure, change in family circumstances, new behaviour risk, repeated missed sessions or concerns about the tuition environment, the risk assessment is reviewed and updated.

22. Attendance, Missed Sessions and Welfare Checks

Attendance concerns can be safeguarding concerns. A child repeatedly missing tuition, disappearing during online sessions, being withdrawn suddenly, or being repeatedly unavailable may indicate anxiety, neglect, family stress, exploitation, school avoidance, domestic abuse, illness or another welfare issue.

Tutors report to Polygon Pedagogues if a child repeatedly misses sessions, parents or carers cancel frequently at short notice, the child appears frightened or unusually distressed, the family becomes unreachable, the learner disappears during an online session, or the tutor arrives and no responsible adult is present. The concern is recorded even if there may be a reasonable explanation.

Where tuition is commissioned by a school or local authority, Polygon Pedagogues reports attendance concerns according to the agreed contract and safeguarding process. A scheduled session in which a learner is unexpectedly absent or unreachable is escalated under the attendance process once 15 minutes have passed, unless there is a known, safe explanation.

Where tuition is arranged privately, Polygon Pedagogues considers whether welfare contact, advice to parents or carers, a referral or another safeguarding response is needed.

23. Allegations Against Staff, Tutors, Volunteers or Directors

Any allegation or concern about an adult working with children is taken seriously. An allegation may meet the harm threshold where an adult has behaved in a way that has harmed a child or may have harmed a child, possibly committed a criminal offence against or related to a child, behaved towards a child in a way that indicates they may pose a risk of harm, or behaved in a way that indicates they may not be suitable to work with children.

If an allegation is made, the person receiving it reports it immediately to the DSL or Deputy DSL. If it concerns the Primary DSL, report it to the Deputy DSL and seek LADO advice; if it concerns the Deputy DSL or Company Director, report it to the Primary DSL and seek LADO advice; if it concerns both, report it directly to the LADO. Do not tell the subject of the allegation until appropriate advice has been taken where early notification could affect a police, social-care or LADO process.

The immediate safety of the child is considered first. If a child is at immediate risk, emergency services or children's social care are contacted without delay. The LADO is contacted as soon as possible, normally within one working day, where an allegation meets or may meet the harm threshold. Decisions about suspension, redeployment, supervision or other interim measures are risk-based and recorded.

Suspension is not automatic, but it may be necessary where children could be at risk, evidence could be interfered with, or the allegation is so serious that continuing work would be inappropriate. All actions are fair, confidential, proportionate and focused on child protection.

24. Low-Level Concerns About Adults

A low-level concern is any concern about an adult's behaviour that does not appear to meet the harm threshold but may still be inconsistent with the staff code of conduct or professional expectations. The term low-level does not mean unimportant. Small concerns can reveal patterns over time and may prevent more serious harm if addressed early.

Examples may include being overly familiar with a child, sharing personal contact details, communicating outside approved channels, using inappropriate language, giving personal gifts, taking photographs without approval, showing favouritism, making comments that cause unease, meeting a child without approval, or breaching online safety rules.

All low-level concerns are reported to the DSL or senior leader and recorded. Polygon Pedagogues responds proportionately and fairly. Action may include clarification of expectations, advice, training, supervision, management action, disciplinary action, referral to the LADO, or escalation if patterns emerge.

Staff are encouraged to self-report if they believe they may have acted in a way that could be misunderstood or may not meet the expected standard. Self-reporting promotes transparency and allows issues to be addressed before they become more serious.

25. Whistleblowing

All staff and tutors have a duty to raise concerns about unsafe practice, poor safeguarding culture, failure to follow procedures, attempts to cover up concerns, or the conduct of colleagues. Whistleblowing is an important part of creating a safe organisation and is treated seriously and respectfully.

Staff normally raise concerns with the DSL, Deputy DSL or Director. If they feel unable to raise the concern internally, believe that the concern involves senior leaders, or believe that concerns have not been properly addressed, they may contact the relevant local authority safeguarding team, the LADO, the police, the NSPCC whistleblowing advice line, DBS or another appropriate external body.

No staff member is treated unfairly for raising a genuine safeguarding concern in good faith. Retaliation, intimidation, exclusion or negative treatment because someone raised a safeguarding concern is treated as a serious conduct issue.

26. Working with Parents and Carers

Polygon Pedagogues values partnership with parents and carers. Parents and carers receive clear information about safeguarding expectations before tuition begins, including the requirement for a responsible adult to be present during home tuition, the need for safe online arrangements, and the importance of sharing relevant information about the child's needs.

Parents and carers provide accurate information about the child's learning, SEND, medical, behavioural and welfare needs where this affects safe tuition. They treat tutors professionally, ensure the learning environment is suitable, avoid leaving tutors alone in sole charge of children, and raise concerns promptly if they are worried about any aspect of tuition.

Where parents or carers do not follow safety requirements, Polygon Pedagogues may suspend, amend or stop tuition. This may happen, for example, where a responsible adult is repeatedly absent, the environment is unsafe, communication becomes inappropriate, or safeguarding information is withheld in a way that may affect the child's safety.

27. Working with Schools, Local Authorities and Other Agencies

Where Polygon Pedagogues works with schools, local authorities or other organisations, safeguarding information is shared appropriately and lawfully. The purpose of information sharing is to make sure that adults around the child have the information they need to keep the child safe and support their education.

Before commissioned tuition begins, Polygon Pedagogues confirms the safeguarding contacts, attendance reporting routes, emergency procedures, referral expectations and information-sharing arrangements. Where a child has an EHCP, child in need plan, child protection plan, early help plan or other professional support, Polygon Pedagogues clarifies what information is relevant to safe tuition and who needs updates.

Polygon Pedagogues cooperates with early help, child in need, child protection, looked-after child, youth justice, health or other professional processes where appropriate. If there is disagreement between agencies and Polygon Pedagogues believes a child remains at risk, the concern is escalated through local safeguarding escalation procedures.

28. Training and Induction

All staff and tutors complete safeguarding training before working with children. Training is appropriate to the role and covers recognising abuse, neglect and exploitation; responding to disclosures; reporting procedures; online safety; professional boundaries; child-on-child abuse; SEND and additional vulnerability; Prevent awareness; FGM awareness; domestic abuse; information sharing; low-level concerns; allegations; and safe working practice for home and online tuition.

Induction explains the identity and contact details of the DSL and Deputy DSL, how to report concerns, where this policy is stored, what to do in an emergency, and how the staff code of conduct applies to real tuition situations. Staff confirm that they have read and understood this policy before working with learners.

The Primary DSL holds Level 3 safeguarding training. Both DSLs complete advanced safeguarding training appropriate to their role and refresh it regularly. They also keep their knowledge updated through local safeguarding partnership updates, statutory guidance changes, case learning, supervision, professional networks and relevant safeguarding briefings.

Safeguarding updates are provided at least annually and whenever significant changes occur. Training records are maintained, and staff who fail to complete required training may be prevented from working with learners until training is complete.

29. Quality Assurance and Monitoring

Polygon Pedagogues monitors safeguarding practice to make sure this policy is being followed in reality, not only written on paper. Quality assurance includes review of safeguarding records, attendance concerns, complaints, safer recruitment files, training compliance, allegations, low-level concerns, tutor feedback and parent or commissioner feedback.

Safeguarding is a standing agenda item in management meetings. The DSL identifies patterns, learning points and areas for improvement, and senior leaders ensure that action is taken. Where an incident reveals a weakness in policy, training, communication, record keeping or risk assessment, Polygon Pedagogues updates practice promptly.

Quality assurance is constructive but rigorous. The aim is not to blame staff for raising concerns; it is to strengthen the organisation's ability to protect children, support tutors and respond consistently.

30. Complaints

Parents, carers, learners, staff and commissioners may raise complaints about safeguarding, conduct, tuition arrangements or professional practice. Complaints involving child safety are prioritised and referred to the DSL immediately.

If a complaint includes an allegation against an adult working with children, the allegations procedure is followed rather than treating the matter only as a customer service complaint. If the complaint suggests that a child is at immediate risk, emergency safeguarding action is taken.

Complaints are handled fairly, confidentially and promptly. However, confidentiality does not prevent information being shared where necessary to safeguard a child or cooperate with statutory agencies.

31. Policy Review

This policy is reviewed annually by the DSL and approved by senior leadership. It is also reviewed sooner if law or guidance changes, local safeguarding procedures change, the business model changes, a serious safeguarding incident occurs, a complaint identifies a weakness, or monitoring shows that procedures need improvement.

All staff and tutors are informed of significant changes. Where changes affect day-to-day practice, staff may be required to complete additional training or confirm again that they have read and understood the policy. The most current version of the policy is available to all staff and tutors.

The review process is not limited to checking dates. It tests whether the policy remains accurate, practical, understood by staff, aligned with current safeguarding expectations and suitable for the actual services delivered by Polygon Pedagogues.

Appendix A: Safeguarding Reporting Procedure

This reporting procedure explains the route from concern to action and is used alongside professional judgement. Where a child is in immediate danger, staff call 999 before following any internal process.

Stage	Expected action
1. Concern arises	A tutor or staff member notices, hears, receives or suspects something concerning. This may be a disclosure, observation, pattern of absence, online incident, behaviour change, injury, environmental concern or professional conduct concern.
2. Immediate safety decision	The adult considers whether the child is in immediate danger or needs urgent medical help. If yes, 999 is called immediately. The adult then informs the DSL as soon as it is safe to do so.
3. Report internally	If the matter is not an emergency, the concern is still reported to the DSL as soon as possible and always within 24 hours. Urgent concerns are reported by phone or another immediate method.
4. Record accurately	The adult records the concern factually, using the child's own words where possible. The record avoids assumptions and clearly separates facts from professional judgement.
5. DSL decision	The DSL considers the information, checks existing records, seeks advice if necessary, and decides whether the response involves monitoring, parental contact, early help, children's social care, police, LADO or another agency.
6. Follow-up	The DSL records the decision, monitors outcomes, follows up referrals and escalates if the child's situation does not improve or if the response from other agencies appears insufficient.

Appendix B: Safeguarding Concern Record Template

This template is completed as soon as possible after a concern arises. If there is immediate risk, emergency action is taken first. The completed record is sent to the DSL securely and is not stored on a personal device or personal email account.

Field	Details
Child's full name	[]
Date of birth / year group	[]
Parent / carer name	[]
Tutor / staff member reporting	[]
Date and time of concern	[]
Location / session type	[Home / online / school / community / other:]
What happened?	[] [] []
Exact words used by the child, if applicable	[] []
What was observed?	[] []
Any injuries seen?	[]
Who else was present?	[]
Immediate action taken	[] []
Was the child in immediate danger?	[Yes / No / Unsure:]
Was 999 called?	[Yes / No:]
Was parent / carer informed?	[Yes / No / Not appropriate:]
Date and time reported to DSL	[]
DSL decision / action	[] []
Referral made?	[Yes / No:]
Agency contacted	[]

Outcome / follow-up	
Record completed by	
Date	

Appendix C: Staff and Tutor Declaration

Every person working for or on behalf of Polygon Pedagogues confirms that they have read and understood this safeguarding policy before working with learners. Signing this declaration does not replace training, supervision or safe recruitment checks; it confirms that the staff member understands the expectations in this document.

Declaration	I confirm that I have read and understood the Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy for Polygon Pedagogues. I understand that safeguarding is everyone's responsibility. I understand that I report all safeguarding concerns to the DSL as soon as possible and always within 24 hours, unless the child is in immediate danger, in which case I call 999 first. I understand that I never promise confidentiality to a child. I understand that I follow the professional boundaries and safe working practices set out in this policy.
Name	
Role	
Signature	
Date	

Appendix D: Emergency and Local Safeguarding Contacts

Use the safeguarding route for the child's usual residence and any agreed commissioning arrangements. If a child is in immediate danger or needs urgent medical attention, call 999 first.

Contacts below were checked on 1 September 2026. Local authority routes can change; verify the current route online at the point of referral.

Area / service	Contact route
Emergency services	999 — immediate danger or urgent medical emergency.
Lewisham: child protection / referral	Family Thrive and Children's Social Care (FFCP): 020 8314 6660 (Mon–Fri, 9am–5pm); Emergency Duty Team: 020 8314 6000 (out of hours); MashAgency@lewisham.gov.uk
Lewisham: LADO	020 8314 7280; LewishamLADO@lewisham.gov.uk
Southwark: child protection / referral	MASH: 020 7525 1921 (weekdays); out of hours: 020 7525 5000; MASH@southwark.gov.uk
Southwark: LADO	020 7525 0689 or 020 7525 3297; qau.safeguarding@southwark.gov.uk
Lambeth: child protection / referral	Integrated Referral Hub: 020 7926 3100 (Mon–Fri, 9am–5pm); Emergency Duty Team: 020 7926 5555; helpandprotection@lambeth.gov.uk
Lambeth: LADO	020 7926 4679 or 07720 828 700; lado@lambeth.gov.uk